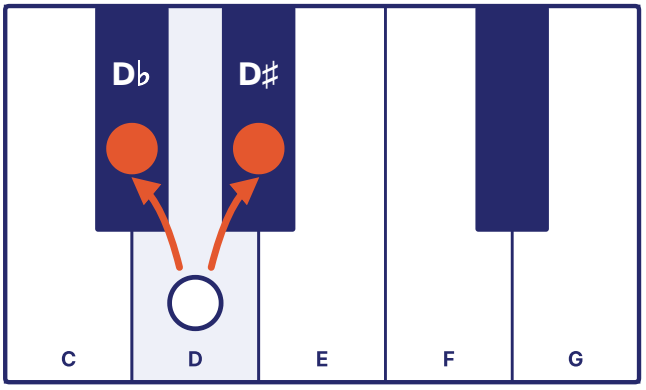
PART I · PITCH · 6

Sharps, flats and naturals

A sign in front of a note moves it to the very next key. **Sharp**: one key to the **right**, a **semitone** higher. **Flat**: one key to the **left**, a semitone lower. Usually that next key is black, which is how the black keys get their names.

THE SECRET

Sharp: the very next key to the right. Flat: the very next key to the left.



♯ one key right · ♭ one key left

SIGN	NAME	WHAT IT DOES	FIRST MET
♯	sharp	one key to the right (a semitone higher)	Level 0
♭	flat	one key to the left (a semitone lower)	Level 0
♮	natural	cancels a sharp or flat: back to the white key	Level ½

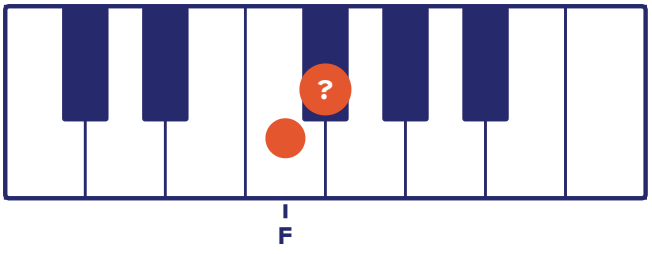
A **semitone** is the smallest step on the piano: from one key to the very next, black or white (American books call it a *half step*). More on p. 43.

THE RULE

A sign belongs to one note. It changes only that line or space, in that octave, and only until the bar line. The same letter in another octave, and every other note, stays as it is.

EXAMPLE 1

Find F♯



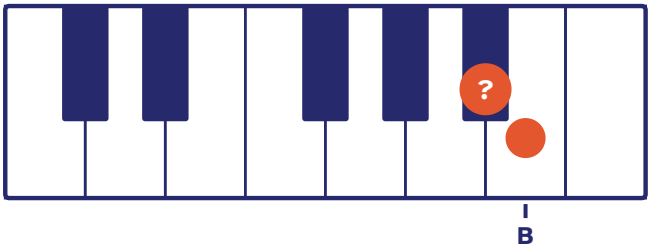
1. **Find F** (the red dot): just left of the three black keys.
2. **Sharp means right:** move to the very next key.
3. **Is it black or white?** Put your finger on it.

The **?** is **F♯**: the first black key of the group of three.

PART I · PITCH · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Find B♭
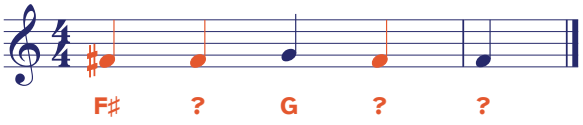


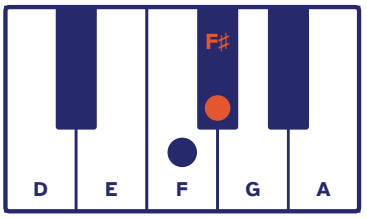
1. **Find B** (the red dot): just right of the three black keys.
2. **Flat means left:** move to the very next key.
3. **Which black key is it?**

The **?** is **B♭**: the top black key of the group of three.

EXAMPLE 3

How long does the sharp last?



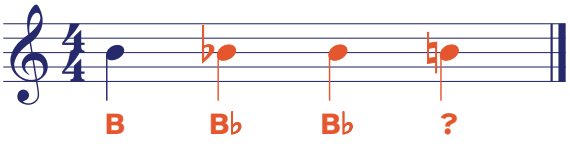


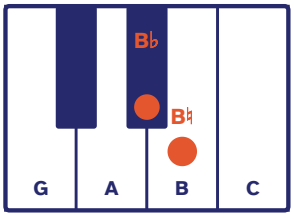
1. **The first note** has a sharp: F♯.
2. **Later in the same bar** there is no sign. Is it still sharp?
3. **After the bar line**: is it still sharp?

Still **F♯** until the bar line; after it, plain **F** again. A sign lasts **to the end of its bar**.

EXAMPLE 4

A natural cancels the flat
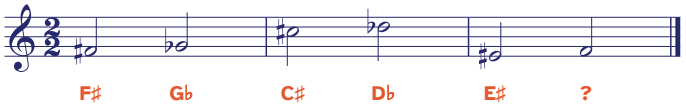




1. **B**: the white key.
2. **B♭**: one key left, and it stays flat for the rest of the bar.
3. **The last note** has a natural sign: what does it do?

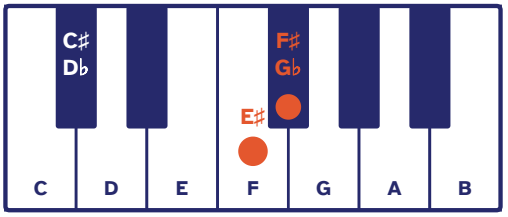
The natural **cancels** the flat: back to the white key B, until the bar line.

PART I · PITCH · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 5

One key, two names





1 **The first bar:** F♯, then G♭. Find both on the keyboard.

2 **Are they different keys?**

3 **The last bar:** E♯. Which key is one right of E?

F♯ and G♭ are the **same black key**; E♯ is the white key **F**. Same sound, different names: **enharmonic**.

GAME

Which key is it?
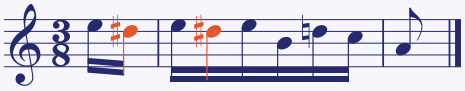
1	2	3	4
C♯	E♭	B♯	F♭

Sharp: one key to the right. Flat: one key to the left. Which key do you press?

Answer: 1 the black key right of C · 2 the black key left of E · 3 the white key C · 4 the white key E.

YOU KNOW THIS

Für Elise (Beethoven)



E, **D♯**, E, **D♯**: the very next key down and back. The sharp is written again in the new bar, because the bar line wiped it out. Later in that bar the D has a **natural**: without it, it would still be D♯.

Try it. Play E and D♯ back and forth: the black key just left of E.

THINK OF IT A sharp or flat is a sticky note on one line of the staff: it stays stuck until the bar line, then it falls off.

TRAP

× Carrying a sharp or flat past the bar line: after it, the note is plain again.

SEE ALSO

Keys and key signatures p. 99

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 6 · Online: Accidentals · Tones & Semitones